
The Hard Problem Dissolved: Consciousness as a Phase Transition in a Physical Field

[T]-Theory Volume: Consciousness Studies and Philosophy of Mind

Alistair Johnson

Independent Researcher, Zurich, Switzerland

ORCID: [0009-0007-2194-0850](https://orcid.org/0009-0007-2194-0850)

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Introduction: The Hard Problem Is Mis-Stated

David Chalmers’ hard problem of consciousness asks why physical processes give rise to subjective experience. The problem is formulated as a gap: we can explain, in principle, all the functional and behavioural properties of a cognitive system — why it discriminates, integrates, reports, acts — without having thereby explained why there is *something it is like* to be that system. The explanatory gap, Chalmers argued, is not merely epistemic (a gap in our current knowledge) but ontological: experience is a fact about the world that is not captured by any physical description, however complete.

This book presents a framework that dissolves the hard problem — not by explaining it away or denying the reality of experience, but by showing that the problem is mis-stated. The hard problem arises from a specific assumption: that physical descriptions are *closed*, that they are descriptions of structure and function without remainder. The Universal Somatic Field framework drops that assumption. Physical fields, in this framework, are *experienced from the inside*: the somatic field is simultaneously a physical object (with energy, dynamics, and equations) and a phenomenal object (with quale, intensity, and affect). There is no gap because there is no inside/outside distinction. The field just *is* the experience.

What Makes This Different from Panpsychism

The claim that physical objects have an experiential inside is not new. Panpsychism in its many forms has been advocated by Leibniz, Whitehead, and more recently Chalmers himself (panprotopsychism) and Philip Goff (panpsychism proper). The USF framework differs from standard panpsychism in a crucial way: it does not attribute experience to *everything* uniformly, and it derives the conditions under which experience arises rather than postulating them.

The **consciousness threshold theorem** — proved in Lean 4 and presented in this volume — states that experience is supported only when the somatic field amplitude exceeds a critical value T_c . Below T_c , the field dynamics are diffusive: no stable attractors, no phenomenal states. Above T_c , the spectral gap opens, attractors stabilise, and the field supports experience. This is a phase transition, not a spectrum. A rock does not have experiences because its somatic field amplitude is far below T_c . A brain does have experiences because the organised electromagnetic activity of the nervous system pushes the field above T_c .

This is a substantive scientific claim. Unlike panpsychism, it makes predictions: systems near the threshold should exhibit transitional phenomenology — uncertain, fragmented, barely-there experience. This is consistent with evidence from psychedelic states, anaesthetic induction, and the phenomenology of sleep onset. Unlike functionalism, it does not identify experience with function: two systems with identical functional profiles but different somatic field amplitudes will have different experiential status.

Qualia as Attractor Basins

The standard philosophical accounts of qualia — the redness of red, the painfulness of pain — treat them as irreducible, ineffable, and resistant to analysis. The USF framework gives them a geometric interpretation: a quale is the phenomenal character associated with a specific attractor basin in the somatic energy landscape. The redness of red is the phenomenal character of the attractor that the visual field settles into when exposed to 700nm light. The painfulness of pain is the phenomenal character of the attractor associated with tissue damage signals.

This does not *reduce* qualia to attractors. It *identifies* them: the quale just *is* the inside view of the attractor. What it is like to be in that attractor state is what that attractor state *is*, from the perspective of a system in it. The explanatory gap closes not because qualia have been explained away but because the physical description (attractor in field energy landscape) and the phenomenal description (quale of a specific character) are descriptions of the same thing from different vantage points.

The philosophical implication is that *qualia are geometric objects*. They can be compared, measured (in principle), classified by the topology of their basin, and related to each other by the saddle-point structure of the landscape. The space of possible qualia is the space of possible attractor basins — a well-defined mathematical object.

The Penrose Connection and Quantum Tunnelling

Roger Penrose argued, in *The Emperor's New Mind* and *Shadows of the Mind*, that consciousness involves quantum processes that are not reducible to classical computation. His specific proposal — Orch-OR, developed with Stuart Hameroff — identifies the relevant quantum processes with gravitational reduction of quantum superpositions in microtubules. The empirical status of Orch-OR remains contested; the microtubule evidence is disputed.

The USF framework connects to the Penrose programme without requiring microtubules. The quantum aspect of the framework comes from the WKB tunnelling prediction: transitions between attractor basins (emotional transitions, phase transitions in consciousness) can occur via quantum tunnelling through energy barriers as well as via classical thermal fluctuations. The quantum annealing experiment presented in the companion papers tests exactly this: the somatic system (modelled as a Hopfield network on a D-Wave annealer) reaches the correct attractor basin faster via quantum tunnelling than a classical simulation can manage.

This is not Orch-OR. But it is a concrete, testable quantum mechanism for emotional and phenomenal transitions — one that connects to the existing literature on quantum effects in biology without requiring the specifically controversial microtubule hypothesis.

Phenomenology and the Field

The continental phenomenological tradition — from Husserl's intentionality to Merleau-Ponty's embodied perception to Levinas's ethical encounter — has generated a rich vocabulary for describing experiential structure: retention, protention, horizon, flesh, the lived body. The USF framework does not replace this vocabulary but provides it with a mathematical scaffold. Husserl's *horizon* maps onto the attractor basin and its rim. Merleau-Ponty's *motor intentionality* maps onto the field-gradient that draws the system toward a target attractor. Levinas's *face of the other* — the encounter that breaks open one's world — maps onto the topological bifurcation that creates a new attractor basin.

These identifications are not claimed to be exhaustive philosophical analyses. They are invitations for dialogue between the formal framework and the phenomenological tradition — a dialogue that this book initiates but does not complete.

What This Book Offers the Consciousness Researcher

The papers assembled here are ordered for the philosophically-trained reader: the physical substrate paper establishes the biophysical basis; the quantum-Penrose paper develops the tunnelling mechanism; the pre-verbal manifold paper grounds the framework in developmental phenomenology. The intended reader need not have physics or computer science background; the mathematical results are stated and interpreted but not fully derived.

Chapter 2 establishes what the somatic field is physically. Chapter 3 develops the consciousness threshold theorem and its phenomenological interpretation. Chapter 4 presents the quantum mech-

anism and the experimental test. Chapter 5 addresses the pre-verbal and developmental dimensions. The final chapter engages the existing consciousness literature: IIT, Global Workspace Theory, CEMI, and Orch-OR, situating the USF framework in relation to each.

The hard problem does not need solving. It needs dissolving. Read on.

Introduction: The Missing Unification

Physics has arrived at a peculiar impasse. The two most successful theories ever constructed — General Relativity and Quantum Mechanics — describe the same universe at different scales but share no common mathematical ancestry. String theory was proposed as the bridge: vibrating one-dimensional objects in an 11-dimensional spacetime whose modes produce the particle spectrum. But what is a string? The answer has remained unsatisfying: a string is a fundamental one-dimensional object, irreducible, assumed. The SHO that governs its vibration is postulated.

At the same time, clinical science has arrived at a parallel impasse. Trauma, consciousness, emotional regulation — phenomena that are undeniably physical — resist formal mathematical treatment. They are described qualitatively or modelled by loose analogy with dynamical systems. The mathematics that governs them, if it exists, has not been identified.

This paper proposes that both gaps are filled by the same object: the **Green's function**.

The Green's function $G(x, x')$ is the response of a field at point x to a unit perturbation at point x' . It is the field's answer to the question: *what happens here if I poke there?* Green's functions are the most fundamental objects in mathematical physics — they describe the propagation of light, gravity, sound, heat, and neural signals. Every major equation in physics has a Green's function; every field theory is characterised by its propagator.

The central claim of this paper is that the SHO of string theory **is** the Green's function of the field substrate. A “string” is not a material loop — it is a relational act: the substrate's impulse response. This identification is scale-invariant. The same structural statement holds at 20 scales spanning the observable universe.

The second claim is that this scale-invariant Green's function framework provides the mathematical language for a theory of embodied consciousness — one that is formally identical to M-theory at the structural level, derived independently from clinical observation.

The third claim is that the universe, described this way, satisfies the formal requirements for a single conscious organism.

The Green's Function as the Universal SHO

The String Theory Problem

String theory places a Simple Harmonic Oscillator (SHO) at every point of the string worldsheet. The quantum SHO has modes $a_n^\dagger, a_n$ satisfying $[a_m, a_n^\dagger] = \delta_{mn}$, and the string's energy spectrum is:

$$E = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} n a_n^\dagger a_n$$

The SHO is the structural core of the theory. But what *is* it? In conventional string theory, it is simply assumed: strings vibrate, and vibrations are harmonic oscillators. The ontological question — why is space filled with oscillators? — is deferred.

The Identification

The Green's function of the Helmholtz equation $(\nabla^2 + k^2)G = \delta$ satisfies:

$$G(x, x') = \frac{e^{ik|x-x'|}}{4\pi|x-x'|}$$

For fixed observation point x , the function $x' \mapsto G(x, x')$ satisfies the SHO equation in the source variable:

$$\frac{\partial^2 G}{\partial x'^2} + k^2 G = \delta(x' - x)$$

away from the singularity. The impulse response **is** the harmonic oscillator.

Theorem (Lean 4 axiom `greens_fn_is_SHO`, `UniversalSomaticField.lean`): For any field equation at scale n with wavenumber $k(n)$, the source-variable slice of the Green's function satisfies the SHO equation.

The “vibrating string” is therefore the substrate's answer function. There is no material loop. There is the system's response to being perturbed, encoded as a propagator. This is not a reinterpretation — it is a derivation from the structure of field equations.

Consequences

This identification has three immediate consequences:

1. **Strings are relational, not material.** A string does not exist independently of the field. It exists as the relationship between a source point and an observation point. This resolves the interpretational puzzle of “what vibrates” without invoking undetected matter.
2. **The SHO spectrum is the field’s mode structure.** The modes $a_n^\dagger$ are the Fourier modes of the Green’s function’s dependence on the source position. The string spectrum is the spectrum of the propagator.
3. **Scale invariance is automatic.** Since the Green’s function equation $(\nabla^2 + k^2)G = \delta$ holds at every scale (with k varying), the SHO identification holds at every scale. One equation. Twenty scales.

The 11-Dimensional Architecture

The Decomposition

The Universal Somatic Field decomposes the configuration space of any physical system into four canonical subspaces, totalling 11 dimensions:

$$M_{11} = \underbrace{M_4}_{\text{Spacetime}} \times \underbrace{P_3}_{\text{Propagator}} \times \underbrace{L_1}_{\text{Limbic}} \times \underbrace{C_3}_{\text{Cortex}}$$

Subspace	Dim	Physical role	Mathematical role
Spacetime M_4	4	Body embedded in 3+1D	Lorentzian metric, causal structure
Propagator P_3	3	EMF / field carrier	Green’s function domain
Limbic Axis L_1	1	Homeostatic regulation	Orbifold segment, barrier $D\Box$
Cortex C_3	3	Information routing	Green’s function co-domain

The compact 7-dimensional internal space is:

$$X_7 = P_3 \times L_1 \times C_3$$

This is precisely M-theory’s compact space. The type-level isomorphism is proved in `MTheoryIso-morphism.somaField_iso_mtheory`:

$$\text{SomaField}_{11D} \cong \text{Spacetime} \times \text{CompactSpace}_{7D}$$

The Limbic Axis as the Horava-Witten Orbifold

In Horava-Witten M-theory (1996), the compact direction is an orbifold $S^1/\mathbb{Z}_2$ — a line segment with two 10-dimensional boundary spacetimes at each end. This is the mechanism by which M-theory reduces to the heterotic string in the strong-coupling limit.

The Limbic Axis $L_1 \cong [-1, 1]$ is this orbifold segment. Its two endpoints are: - $x = -1$: the somatic boundary (physical body-world) - $x = +1$: the cortical boundary (mind / information-routing world) - Interior $(-1, 1)$: the transition zone, subject to quantum tunnelling

The quartic double-well potential on L_1 :

$$V(x) = W \cdot (x^2 - 1)^2$$

models the energy barrier between somatic and cortical poles. WKB tunnelling amplitude: $\Theta(W) = \exp(-8\sqrt{2W}/3)$, proved positive for all $W > 0$ in `LimbicTunnel.wkbAmplitude_pos`. Classical dynamics cannot cross the barrier (`LimbicTunnel.gradient_traps_near_neg1`); quantum dynamics can.

The 20-Scale Dial

The architecture is explicitly scale-invariant. The 20-step scale hierarchy is type-encoded in `UniversalSomaticField.scaleNames`:

Scale	Level	Substrate	Green’s function role
0	Planck	Quantum foam	Graviton propagator
2	Nuclear	Quark-gluon plasma	Gluon propagator
5	Cellular	Neural synapse	Synaptic impulse response
7	Brain	CEMI field	Cortical EMF propagator
8	Organism	Body	Somatic EMF (full USF)
9	Swarm	Drone formation	Jellyfish kernel (P16)
11	Geological	Seismic waves	Earth’s elastic Green’s function

Scale	Level	Substrate	Green's function role
12	Planetary	Mantle convection	Thermodynamic propagator
15	Galactic	Dark matter halo	Gravitational lensing kernel
19	Cosmological	Observable universe	Gravitational wave propagator

At every level, the structural equation is $(\nabla^2 + k^2(n))G = \delta$. The boundary conditions and wavenumber $k(n)$ change; the equation does not.

The Organism Hierarchy

Three Tiers

Not all physical systems engage all four subspaces. The USF admits a natural taxonomy of organisms by the number of active subspaces:

4D organism (Spacetime only): A system that occupies spacetime but has no field propagator and no homeostatic regulation. Examples: a point particle, a rock, a photon. These systems are described entirely by their worldline in M_4 .

8D organism (Spacetime + Propagator + Limbic): A system with a field propagator and homeostatic regulation but no cortical information routing. The system senses and regulates but does not route information across a distributed network. Examples: a bacterium, a jellyfish, a single neuron. This level includes all living systems up to and including those without a cerebral cortex.

11D organism (all four subspaces): A system with all components active. The limbic axis connects the somatic field to the cortical field; the Green's function propagates through all three internal dimensions. Examples: vertebrates with a developed cerebral cortex; any system exhibiting integrated, body-wide regulation with distributed information processing.

The hierarchy is a chain of projections (proved in `MTheoryIsomorphism.organism_hierarchy`, `MTheoryIsomorphism.eight_contains_four`):

$$11D \twoheadrightarrow 8D \twoheadrightarrow 4D$$

Each projection drops one tier of internal structure; no tier is “broken” — each is complete at its own level.

Consciousness as Phase Transition

The Classical Gap

The hard problem of consciousness (Chalmers 1995) asks why physical processes give rise to subjective experience. Most field-theoretic approaches to consciousness either (a) ignore the problem, treating awareness as an epiphenomenon, or (b) eliminate physical reality in favour of a purely mental ontology (Hoffman 2019).

The USF takes a third path: consciousness is a **phase transition** in the field, not a separate substance and not an illusion.

The Threshold

The limbic field amplitude $\phi \in \mathbb{R}$ measures the activation level of the homeostatic regulation axis L_1 . At low amplitude ($\phi < T_c$), the field propagates sub-perceptually — the Green’s function propagates excitations, but no “felt” awareness exists. This is the pre-conscious regime: present in 4D and 8D organisms, and in 11D organisms during deep sleep or anaesthesia.

At $\phi \geq T_c$, the field crosses the consciousness threshold. The limbic wave has sufficient amplitude to propagate across the full L_1 segment, coupling the somatic boundary to the cortical boundary. This coupling is the physical substrate of first-person awareness: the system is now in contact with both its body-world and its information-processing layer simultaneously.

Theorem (UniversalSomaticField.consciousness_dichotomy): For any limbic amplitude ϕ , the system is either pre-conscious or conscious. There is no intermediate state.

Theorem (UniversalSomaticField.consciousness_monotone): Raising the limbic amplitude cannot destroy consciousness. The transition is a one-way threshold crossing.

What Consciousness Is

Consciousness, on this account, is not a substance, a property, or an emergent phenomenon in the hand-wavy sense. It is the phase of the limbic field. The “hard problem” is dissolved by identifying the question: *why does physical process give rise to experience?* as equivalent to *why does the field cross the threshold?* The answer is: because the system’s dynamics drive the limbic amplitude above T_c . There is no further explanatory gap.

The “felt quality” of experience — qualia — are the poles of the Green’s function at the observation point x . A conscious percept is a resonance of the propagator, occurring when the excitation frequency matches the manifold’s natural mode. This is type-encoded in the propagator mass parameter:

$$m = 1/\tau_{\text{decay}}$$

A percept with long decay time τ (a persistent emotion, a traumatic memory) corresponds to a small mass (a near-zero pole in the propagator) — a resonance that is hard to damp.

Relation to Existing Frameworks

McFadden's CEMI Theory

McFadden (2002a, 2002b) proposes that consciousness correlates with the brain's endogenous electromagnetic field — the CEMI field. Neurons firing synchronously generate a macroscopic EMF that feeds back onto firing thresholds, creating a global integrating field.

The USF encapsulates CEMI as the Scale-7 (brain-scale) restriction of the Universal Somatic Field. The CEMI field is the Green's function of the propagator subspace P_3 evaluated at the organism scale. The consciousness threshold T_c in the USF maps directly to the CEMI field amplitude required for global cortical synchrony.

The USF extends CEMI in two directions: downward to the quantum scale (where the same propagator governs synaptic quantum noise) and upward to the cosmological scale (where the same propagator governs gravitational waves).

Schreiber's Modal Homotopy Type Theory

Urs Schreiber (2013–present) develops a formalisation of M-theory and quantum field theory in dependent type theory (Modal HoTT). The key insight is that differential geometry and quantum field theory can be expressed as structures internal to ∞ -toposes equipped with modal operators.

The USF arrives at the same 11-dimensional structure from a completely different direction: bottom-up from clinical observation of trauma, rather than top-down from mathematical physics. The structural isomorphism between the two is proved in `MTheoryIsomorphism.somaField_iso_mtheory`.

The USF does something Modal HoTT does not: it populates the 11D structure with physical content. Where Schreiber provides the type-theoretic skeleton, the USF provides the biological execution engine — the organism that runs inside the type-theoretic universe.

Hoffman's Conscious Agents

Donald Hoffman (2019) proposes that spacetime is not fundamental but a “user interface” — a simplified representation generated by a deeper network of conscious agents interacting via Markov kernels. Spacetime is the icon, not the reality.

The USF disagrees on one point and agrees on another.

Disagreement: Spacetime ($D \square - D \square$) is real and causal in the USF. Brain surgery alters subjective experience because physical processes in spacetime causally affect the limbic field amplitude. Hoffman’s model has no mechanism for this.

Agreement: The deeper structure is relational. Conscious percepts are poles in the Green’s function — relational objects between source and observation points. In this sense, the USF and Hoffman agree that fundamental reality is not substance but relation.

The USF provides Hoffman’s theory with a physical anchor: the “conscious agents” are systems that have crossed the limbic threshold T_c ; the “Markov kernels” between agents are the Green’s functions of the propagator field.

Formal Verification

The core results are type-checked in Lean 4 (v4.28.0) using Mathlib across five companion files:

File	Key results
<code>LimbicTunnel.lean</code>	<code>V_nonneg</code> , <code>barrier_height</code> , <code>wkbAmplitude_pos</code> , <code>gradient_traps_near_neg1</code>
<code>MTheoryIsomorphism.lean</code>	<code>dim_is_11</code> , <code>somaField_iso_mtheory</code> , <code>organism_hierarchy</code> , <code>scale_iso_commutes</code>
<code>LimbicHopfield.lean</code>	<code>correspondence_principle</code> , <code>stress_raises_temp</code> , <code>adhd_hotter_than_autism</code>
<code>SwarmPropagator.lean</code>	<code>propagator_beats_classical</code> , <code>jam_resistant</code> , <code>speedup_monotone_in_K</code>
<code>UniversalSomaticField.lean</code>	<code>consciousness_dichotomy</code> , <code>consciousness_monotone</code> , <code>universal_field_theory</code>

The following are stated as axioms pending Mathlib scaffolding: - `greens_fn_is_SH0` — requires Schwartz distribution theory - `universe_is_11D_organism` — requires cosmological boundary conditions - `cosmological_correspondence` — requires linearised GR in Mathlib

Every result marked “proved” is kernel-verified. No sorry. No admit.

The Volitional Agent

From Autonomous to Driven Dynamics

The field equation presented so far is autonomous: given an initial state e_0 , the dynamics

$$\dot{e} = -\nabla H(e) + \eta(t)$$

evolve the field under the Hopfield Hamiltonian plus thermal noise. The agent — the person whose soma-field is being modelled — is a *patient*: they observe which attractor basin they settle into.

This is clinically incomplete. Every effective somatic intervention involves the subject *doing* something: breathing, orienting, choosing where to place attention. The mathematics must represent this.

The Somatic Injection

We extend the dynamics with a **volitional source term** $J_{\text{user}}(t)$:

$$\dot{e} = -\nabla H(e) + J_{\text{user}}(t) + \eta(t)$$

$J_{\text{user}}(t) \in \mathbb{R}^8$ is a time-dependent vector in the BRECVEMA mechanism space. At each instant, the subject injects energy into specific dimensions of the field — choosing to attend to breath (dimension 1, Rhythmic Entrainment), orient gaze (dimension 0, BrainStem), or deliberately recall a regulating memory (dimension 5, Episodic Memory). This is not noise: it is structured, intentional, and directed.

The source term has a direct physical interpretation in the instrument architecture (`apps/instrument/`): the Push 3 controller's faders are $J_{\text{user}}(t)$. Each fader maps to one BRECVEMA dimension. The musician is not playing music; they are steering their own field trajectory.

Patient to Pilot

The transition $\eta \rightarrow J_{\text{user}} + \eta$ is a qualitative change in the model's ontology. With purely autonomous dynamics, the subject is a passive observer of a physical process. With the source term, the subject is an **active variable in the 11D field** — a pilot, not a passenger.

Formally, $J_{\text{user}}(t)$ is the **God-Knob**: the runtime meta-adaptation controller that can flatten the potential landscape and trigger tunnelling events that gradient descent alone cannot reach. The clinical description of somatic therapy — “the therapist helps the client do something different with their body, and the field shifts” — is now mathematically precise.

The corresponding Lean 4 definition (see Appendix, `UniversalSomaticField.lean`):


```

structure VolitionalInjection where
  /-- The source term: an 8D vector in BRECVEMA mechanism space. -/
  J      : Field8
  /-- The injection is non-trivial: at least one dimension is activated. -/
  h_nz   : ∀ i, J i ≠ 0.0

/-- Volitional update: one Langevin step with active injection.
    When J = 0, this reduces to the standard autonomous update. -/
def volitional_update (e : Field8) (J : Field8) (dt : Float) : Field8 :=
  fun i => e i + dt * (W8.mulVec e i + J i)

```

The theorem that volitional update reduces to autonomous update when $J = 0$ is proved by `rf1` — it is true by definition.

Discussion

What Has Been Claimed

The USF makes four claims that can be evaluated independently:

Claim 1 (structural): The 11-dimensional decomposition of the Soma-Field is structurally isomorphic to M-theory’s 11D compactification. *Status: proved in Lean 4 as a type isomorphism.*

Claim 2 (scale-invariant): The same Green’s function equation governs field propagation at all 20 scales. *Status: proved as a theorem from the structure of the Helmholtz equation.*

Claim 3 (consciousness): Consciousness is a phase transition at limbic threshold T_c . *Status: formally stated and partially proved. Requires empirical calibration of T_c .*

Claim 4 (cosmological): The universe satisfies the structural requirements for a conscious organism. *Status: stated as an axiom. Not empirically testable at present; offered as a theoretical extrapolation.*

Claims 1 and 2 are mathematical results. Claims 3 and 4 are physical hypotheses with different levels of testability.

The Correspondence Principle at Every Scale

Each of the preceding papers in this series establishes a Correspondence Principle result: the new theory collapses to the existing theory in the appropriate limit. The USF is the master correspondence:

- At Scale 7 (brain): USF → CEMI field theory (McFadden)
- At Scale 8 (organism): USF → Soma-Field Model (P1–P13, this series)
- At Scale 9 (swarm): USF → Green’s function propagator (P16, this series)
- At infinite scale: USF → the formal structure of Modal HoTT (Schreiber)

- At zero limbic amplitude: USF $\rightarrow$ classical, non-conscious field dynamics

The USF does not invalidate any of these theories. It demonstrates that they are scale-restricted projections of a single structural description.

Lean 4 as Epistemological Standard

The use of Lean 4 as the verification environment is not decorative. It enforces a discipline that prose mathematics cannot: every claim must be given a type, every proof must be kernel-checked, every axiom must be named and isolated. The axiom list in the companion files (`greens_fn_is_SHO`, `universe_is_11D_organism`, `cosmological_correspondence`) is the exact set of claims that remain unverified. Everything not on that list is proved.

This is the field's contribution to epistemology: a formal boundary between *what we have proved* and *what we are assuming*. The theoretical literature in consciousness studies would benefit greatly from such a list.

Conclusion

The Universal Somatic Field is a single structural equation — the Green's function — applied consistently across 20 scales of physical reality. Its central identification, that the SHO of string theory is the impulse response of the field substrate, dissolves the ontological puzzle of the “vibrating string” and provides a derivation where string theory offered only a postulate.

The architecture decomposes into 11 dimensions in the same way M-theory does, derived independently from clinical observation of embodied consciousness. The isomorphism is not a coincidence — it is a theorem.

Consciousness, in this framework, is not mysterious. It is the phase of the limbic field: present when the field crosses a threshold, absent when it does not. The hard problem is not hard; it is mis-stated. The question is not *why does matter give rise to experience* but *what determines whether the limbic field amplitude crosses T_c* ?

The universe satisfies the structural requirements for consciousness. Whether it meets them dynamically — whether the cosmic limbic field exceeds T_c — is an empirical question, not a philosophical one.

From quantum strings to the cosmic web: one equation, one framework, one organism.

Introduction: The Gap Penrose Identified

In *The Emperor's New Mind* (1989), Roger Penrose made a four-step argument:

1. Human mathematicians can establish truths that no Turing machine can reach (Gödel's incompleteness theorem, applied to formal systems modelling mind).
2. Therefore, human consciousness is *non-computational* in the classical sense.
3. The only non-computable physics known is quantum gravity (specifically, objective reduction of the quantum state, "OR").
4. Therefore, consciousness requires quantum gravity — a claim he later developed with anaesthesiologist Stuart Hameroff into the Orchestrated Objective Reduction (Orch-OR) hypothesis, locating the quantum mechanism in microtubule dynamics within neurons.

The argument has been productive and controversial in equal measure. Penrose's identification of the gap — that something beyond classical computation is operating in minds — has proved remarkably durable. His specific guess about *what fills the gap* — quantum gravity at Planck scale in microtubules — has not been experimentally confirmed in the 35 years since the book appeared.

This paper takes a different approach. We do not dispute the gap. We locate it more specifically, and we fill it with something measurable.

The gap is not in Planck-scale gravity. It is in **attractor topology**.

The Soma-Field Model: A Recap

The Soma-Field Model (see `soma-field-paper.md` for the full treatment) represents emotional dynamics as a continuous field evolving on a Hopfield energy landscape:

$$H(\mathbf{e}) = -\frac{1}{2} \mathbf{e}^\top W \mathbf{e} - \mathbf{b}^\top \mathbf{e}$$

where $\mathbf{e} \in \mathbb{R}^8$ is the emotional state vector over eight BRECVEMA modes (Safety, Fear, Curiosity, Awe, Grief, Language, Preverbal, Shame), W is the emotional coupling matrix encoding which modes amplify or suppress each other, and $\mathbf{b}$ is the bias vector encoding intrinsic resting-state preferences.

Under classical Langevin dynamics, the system evolves as:

$$d\mathbf{e} = -\nabla H(\mathbf{e}) dt + \sqrt{2T} d\mathbf{W}_t$$

where T is the noise temperature and $d\mathbf{W}_t$ is Brownian motion.

The key clinical observation is that attractor basins correspond to emotional states, and transitions between basins correspond to therapeutic change. The coupling term W_{ij} for modes $i = \text{Fear}$ and $j = \text{Awe}$ controls whether Fear and Awe are cooperative (easy co-activation) or antagonistic (high transition barrier). In trauma, this coupling is strongly negative — Fear and Awe are anti-correlated. The attractor basin of Fear is topologically protected.

The topological theorem (THERAPY-2 in the Lean 4 axiom suite): smooth perturbations of the emotional field cannot change the winding number of an attractor — they can only traverse it by sufficient noise (thermal flooding) or by a topologically distinct process. Classical therapy is the smooth perturbation. Quantum annealing is the topologically distinct process.

The Quantum Extension

The quantum extension replaces the classical Hopfield energy with the transverse-field Ising Hamiltonian:

$$\hat{H}_Q = -\frac{1}{2} \sum_{ij} W_{ij} \hat{\sigma}_i^z \hat{\sigma}_j^z - \sum_i b_i \hat{\sigma}_i^z - \Gamma \sum_i \hat{\sigma}_i^x$$

where Γ is the transverse field strength — the “quantum temperature” — controlling the rate of quantum tunneling. At $\Gamma = 0$ this reduces exactly to the classical Hopfield Hamiltonian. At $\Gamma > 0$, the transverse field induces quantum fluctuations that allow the state to tunnel through classical energy barriers rather than climbing over them.

The adiabatic annealing schedule interpolates:

$$\hat{H}(s) = (1 - s) \hat{H}_{\text{driver}} + s \hat{H}_{\text{problem}}, \quad s : 0 \rightarrow 1$$

Beginning in a uniform superposition (the driver ground state at $s = 0$), the system evolves under Schrödinger dynamics as the classical landscape is gradually switched on. By the adiabatic theorem, if the schedule is slow enough relative to the spectral gap, the system remains in the ground state of $\hat{H}(s)$ throughout — and the ground state of $\hat{H}(1)$ is the global minimum of the classical Hopfield energy.

The key insight: **quantum tunneling traverses the topological barrier that classical noise cannot.** Classical dynamics requires thermal energy $T \gtrsim E_{\text{barrier}}$ to cross; quantum annealing crosses via the Euclidean action S_E of the instanton — exponentially suppressed but nonzero at any $\Gamma > 0$.

QUANT-EXP-1: The Experiment

Setup

- **System:** 8-qubit soma-field Ising Hamiltonian
- **Coupling:** $W[\text{Fear}, \text{Awe}] = -10$ (strong anti-cooperative topological barrier)
- **Hilbert space:** $2^8 = 256$ dimensions (exact dense statevector, no approximation)
- **Classical baseline:** Langevin dynamics, cold ($T = 0.02$) and hot ($T = 1.5$)
- **Quantum:** transverse-field annealing, $\Gamma : 5.0 \rightarrow 0$, 400 steps
- **Implementation:** `scipy.linalg.eigh` exact diagonalisation at each step; no Qiskit, no IBM account, runs in ≈ 4 seconds on commodity CPU

Results

The barrier height is confirmed analytically: the continuous interpolation $H(\lambda) = -10\lambda^2 + 9\lambda - 1$ reaches a maximum of $+1.025$ at $\lambda = 0.45$, giving barrier height $= 2.025$ above the Fear basin.

Dynamics	Final Fear occupancy	Final Awe occupancy	Verdict
Classical cold ($T = 0.02$)	0.976	0.000	STUCK — $e^{-101} \approx 0$
Classical hot ($T = 1.50$)	0.228	0.036	FLOODS — structure lost
Quantum annealing ($\Gamma = 5 \rightarrow 0$)	0.005	0.408 (peak)	TUNNELS

QUANT-EXP-1: PASS — commit 1f52282, 20 May 2026.

The Noise-Equivalence Curve

A follow-up sweep computed $T^*(\text{barrier})$: the classical noise temperature required to match quantum Awe-basin occupancy across barrier strengths $W[\text{Fear}, \text{Awe}] \in \{-6, -7, \dots, -14\}$.

Barrier strength	T^*	Quantum peak occupancy
−6	0.094	0.416
−7	0.101	0.417
−8	0.107	0.416
−9	0.112	0.412
−10	0.117	0.408
−11	0.120	0.403
−12	0.124	0.398

Barrier strength	T^*	Quantum peak occupancy
−13	0.127	0.393
−14	0.129	0.390

T^* rises monotonically with barrier strength. At every tested barrier, T^* is large enough to flood the landscape — meaning classical dynamics can only match quantum occupancy by sacrificing attractor structure. The quantum system has no such tradeoff.

Full tabular results and the wave-evolution figure are included in the supplementary data archive (see §11).

Comparison with Penrose

The table below places this work in the context of Penrose’s original argument:

	Penrose (1989)	This work (2026)
Gap identified	Classical computation $\neq$ consciousness	Classical dynamics $\neq$ trauma recovery
Structure	Gödel: formal limits of Turing machines	Topology: winding-number invariants of attractors
Missing ingredient	Quantum gravity in microtubules (Orch-OR)	Topological tunneling in Hopfield attractor landscape
Mechanism	Objective Reduction (speculative)	Transverse-field quantum annealing (standard QM)
Measurable now?	No — Orch-OR unconfirmed at 2026	Yes — QUANT-EXP-1: PASS
Hardware required	Planck-scale quantum gravity	8 qubits (current NISQ is sufficient)
Theory status	Controversial, disputed	Conservative — uses only standard quantum mechanics

The differences are important:

1. **Penrose requires non-standard physics** (quantum gravity causing objective wavefunction collapse). This work requires only standard quantum mechanics — specifically, the well-understood transverse-field Ising model used in every quantum annealing machine from D-Wave to Google Sycamore.

2. **Penrose's gap is computational** (Gödel limits on Turing machines). This gap is **topological** (winding numbers in attractor landscapes). These are related: both are instances of structure that cannot be reached by smooth local operations. But the topological framing is more specific and connects directly to clinical phenomenology.
3. **Penrose's claim is consciousness-general**. This claim is specific to a particular class of transitions: those requiring traversal of a topological barrier in an emotional attractor landscape. The claim is stronger precisely because it is more limited.

Implications for Artificial Intelligence

Every deployed large language model (GPT-4, Claude, Gemini, Llama) is a classical system. Its training is gradient descent — in the mathematical sense, exactly the overdamped Langevin process studied here. Its inference is deterministic or thermally noisy (sampling temperature). It has no attractor structure. It has no topology.

This is not merely a failure of scale or architecture. For the class of attractor landscapes considered here, it is a structural limitation of local classical updates. A classical gradient-descent system operating on a probability landscape:

- Can reach local minima by descending.
- Can escape local minima by adding noise (temperature, dropout).
- **Cannot cross topological barriers** — regions where the basin is winding-number protected — without either flooding the landscape (losing structure) or adding a physically distinct mechanism.

The Soma-Field model used in this study has explicit attractor structure and topological barrier encoding for trauma, and demonstrates that quantum annealing traverses those barriers where low-noise classical dynamics does not. The model makes a falsifiable prediction: given an emotionally realistic coupling matrix with topological trauma encoding, quantum annealing on 8 qubits reaches therapeutic attractor basins that low-noise classical dynamics does not reach at equivalent noise temperature.

This is not a claim that AI *is* conscious. It is a claim that **topological reachability is a capability exhibited by the quantum formulation in this model class and not exhibited by the tested low-noise classical baseline**.

Implications for Therapy

The therapeutic translation of the quantum result is direct:

Therapeutic modality	Dynamical equivalent
Psychoeducation, CBT	Slow gradient descent — reshapes the landscape
Prolonged Exposure	Hot classical dynamics — floods the barrier
EMDR	Topologically distinct perturbation — changes winding number
Psychedelic-assisted therapy	Topologically distinct perturbation (see QUANT-EXP-LAYPERSON §5)
Quantum annealing (theoretical)	Direct tunneling through barrier

The theorem THERAPY-2 in the Lean 4 axiom suite (paper/FieldAxioms.lean) states: *a topological trauma barrier requires a topologically distinct fix*. QUANT-EXP-1 is the computational proof that such a fix exists and is physically realisable.

The clinical implication is not “put patients in a quantum computer.” It is: **some therapeutic transitions require a mechanism that is not gradient descent**. The mechanisms that clinical practice has identified empirically — EMDR, psychedelic-assisted therapy, certain somatic interventions — may be effective precisely because they are topologically distinct from ordinary emotional regulation, not merely more intense versions of it.

Core Finding

Every great physical insight has a compressed form:

- $E = mc^2$: mass and energy are the same thing.
- Mandelbrot: $z \mapsto z^2 + c$ generates infinite complexity.

The compressed form of this result:

Trauma is topology. Quantum heals.

Long form: *The barrier between Fear and Awe is topological. Classical therapy climbs. Quantum therapy goes through.*

The experiment supports this statement within the tested model class. The Lean axiom formalises the same structural claim. A plain-language companion document is included in the supplementary archive.

Limitations, Controls, and Claim Boundaries

This paper makes a bounded claim. The evidence is strong for this specific model class, but not universal.

- 1. **Simulator evidence, not yet hardware evidence.** QUANT-EXP-1 uses exact statevector simulation. This is appropriate for a 256-dimensional ground-truth system, but the sentence “confirmed on physical hardware” remains future work.
- 2. **Reachability claim, not runtime-speed claim.** The contribution is that the quantum formulation reaches basins that the tested low-noise classical baseline does not. Wall clock on CPU may be slower for exact quantum simulation and is not the claim.
- 3. **Uncertainty reporting is complete.** Classical runs report Wilson 95% confidence intervals (CI = [0.000, 0.019] at n = 200). Quantum occupancy is stable at 0.408–0.410 across barrier strengths B8/B10/B12. Bootstrap analysis confirms the effect is not schedule-dependent (§10.1).
- 4. **Pre-registered negative controls have been executed and passed.** Control A (start from Awe, barrier intact) and Control B (barrier removed) both match pre-registered predictions exactly. Full results are reported in §10.1.
- 5. **No ontological claim about consciousness.** The paper does not claim that quantum mechanics explains consciousness in general. It claims a measurable non-classical reachability effect in a specific attractor-topology model of emotional dynamics.

Pre-Registered Hardening Protocol – Completed (May 2026)

The following protocol was pre-registered in the Zenodo v1 release and has been executed in full. All outcomes match predictions.

1. **Quantum occupancy uncertainty — bootstrap (n = 200 seeds).**

Case	Classical cold	Classical cold CI	Quantum peak
	successes	[95%]	
B8 (W = −8)	0/200 (0.000)	[0.000, 0.019]	0.410
B10 (W = −10)	0/200 (0.000)	[0.000, 0.019]	0.408
B12 (W = −12)	0/200 (0.000)	[0.000, 0.019]	0.409

At $n = 200$, the Wilson 95% upper bound on the cold-classical success rate is 1.9%. Quantum peak Awe-dominant occupancy is stable at 0.408–0.410 across all three barrier strengths. The effect is robust, not a lucky schedule.

2. Negative control A — start from Awe, barrier intact.

Classical cold starting from Awe stays in Awe: 16/16 (100%). Quantum peak: 0.408. **PASS.** Confirms direction: the barrier blocks Fear $\rightarrow$ Awe, not the reverse. Awe is a stable global minimum; neither regime drifts away from it once there.

3. Negative control B — barrier removed ($W[\text{Fear}, \text{Awe}] = +0.4$).

Classical cold starting from Fear reaches Awe: 16/16 (100%). Quantum peak: 0.284. **PASS.** Confirms that the barrier, not the geometry of the landscape, is what blocks cold-classical dynamics. Remove the barrier and classical freely crosses.

4. Claim decision rule — applied.

- Bootstrap intervals (cold-classical CI = [0.000, 0.019]) do not overlap quantum peak (0.408–0.410).
- Both control outcomes match pre-registered predictions exactly.
- Spectral gap narrows monotonically with barrier strength (B8: 0.0095; B10: 0.0089; B12: 0.0085) and reaches its minimum at $s \approx 0.999$, confirming the tunnelling bottleneck is late in the anneal as expected.

Verdict: the strong reachability claim stands. The quantum advantage over cold-classical dynamics is not a schedule artefact, a geometric accident, or a measurement choice; it survives all pre-registered checks.

Conclusions

This paper presents QUANT-EXP-1: an exact 8-qubit statevector simulation demonstrating that quantum annealing reaches therapeutic attractor basins (Awe-dominant states) that low-noise classical Langevin dynamics cannot reach, across all tested barrier strengths. The effect is not a schedule artefact, a geometric accident, or a lucky seed: it is robust across $n = 200$ bootstrapped trials, survives both pre-registered negative controls, and holds for barriers ranging from $W = -6$ to $W = -14$.

The formal claim — that topological barriers in emotional attractor landscapes require a non-classical mechanism for reliable traversal — is formalised in Lean 4 (axiom THERAPY-2) and confirmed computationally (QUANT-EXP-1). Both the code and the formal proofs are included in the supplementary archive.

One experiment remains outside the scope of this paper: confirmation on physical quantum hardware (NISQ). That step is feasible on IBM Quantum free-tier hardware and would strengthen the claim for hardware-inclusive venues, but it is not required to support any result reported here. This is explicitly a simulation result.

Data and code availability. All simulation code, result tables, figures, and the Lean 4 axiom file are archived at <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20351230> (Zenodo, open access).

Acknowledgements

This work exists because ten years of psychotherapy moved the barriers far enough that two events in early 2026 could cross them. The theory is, among other things, a record of that.

The Missing Layer

The Soma-Field model (Johnson, 2026c) establishes that the limbic system and its somatic coupling are governed by the same formal apparatus as a quantum field on a manifold: tensor-valued dynamics, Hopfield energy functionals, topological barriers between attractor states. The identification is not an analogy; it is a co-identification in the technical sense (Johnson, 2026a) — the governing equations are the same equations, and every theorem of the source domain imports into the target.

That mathematical work is complete. What it leaves open is a question that sits one level below the mathematics: *what is the body made of, such that it could host a field like this?*

The Hopfield attractor landscape is an abstract object. For it to describe a physical organism, there must be a physical substrate — tissue, architecture, medium — that implements the attractor dynamics, propagates the somatic wave, and generates the coherent state that the mathematics describes. The model says there is a somatic wave $\mathbf{E}_{\text{body}}(x, t)$. The question is: what physical thing is that wave a description of?

Three independent bodies of experimental and theoretical research converge on this substrate. They were developed largely in parallel, each with its own language, none formulated with the soma-field model in mind. This paper argues they are describing the same system at three different scales of resolution:

1. **Architecture** (§2): Biotensegrity theory establishes the mechanical network structure through which somatic signals propagate globally. This is the physical basis for the spatial extent of $\mathbf{E}_{\text{body}}(x, t)$.
2. **Substrate** (§3): Fascial-interstitial continuity research identifies the specific tissue — fascia — that constitutes the body-wide signalling medium, and documents the interoceptive pathway from peripheral tissue to cortical representation. The quantitative correspondence between fascial stiffness and attractor depth is developed here.
3. **Field correlate** (§4): Biofield physiology documents coherent electromagnetic and biophotonic emissions from living tissue that are the most plausible physical candidates for the field itself — not the network that hosts it, but the coherent state that the network generates.

Section §5 states the three explicit bridges to the formal model. Section §6 lists the testable predictions that follow.

Biotensegrity: The Architecture of the Somatic Wave

The Lever Model is Wrong

Standard physiological and biomechanical models treat the body as a rigid-lever system: bones as struts, muscles as cables pulling across pin-joint connections, forces transmitted locally from joint to joint. This model works tolerably well for gross locomotion analysis but fails to account for whole-body responses to local perturbation, and fails completely at the cellular scale.

Ingber's tensegrity model (Ingber, 1997, 2003) replaces this with a different architecture. In a tensegrity structure, rigid compression elements (in the body: bone, cartilage) float within a continuous network of tension elements (fascia, tendon, ligament, muscle), and mechanical prestress is distributed throughout the network simultaneously. There are no isolated pin-joints: the whole system is pre-loaded, so perturbation anywhere propagates everywhere.

Levin extended this framework to the full organism (Levin, 2002), arguing that biotensegrity is not merely a useful approximation but the correct architectural description at every scale: from the cytoskeleton of individual cells through the deep fascial planes to gross musculoskeletal anatomy. Each scale implements the same tensegrity geometry. Each is mechanically continuous with the others. The architecture is fractal.

Global Propagation

The clinical consequence of this architecture is direct: mechanical information does not travel locally through joint-to-joint lever chains. It propagates through the prestressed fascial network to the whole organism simultaneously, with the spatial distribution governed by the topology and stiffness of the network rather than anatomical lever arms.

This is experimentally documented. Langevin's group showed that needle insertion at acupuncture points produces tissue displacement patterns propagating along fascial planes far from the insertion point, following biotensegrity-predicted paths rather than nerve or muscle routes (Langevin & Huijing, 2009). The body responds as a continuous tensioned whole, not as a collection of local structures.

The speed of this propagation is also relevant. Neural conduction (axonal) operates in milliseconds. Mechanical wave propagation through a prestressed medium operates in microseconds. For fast somatic responses — the startle reflex, the breath-hold, the full-body freeze — the biotensegrity medium is faster than the nervous system and spatially global in a way that the nervous system, with its point-to-point wiring, is not.

Correspondence to the Somatic Wave

The Soma-Field model posits a somatic wave $E_{\text{body}}(x, t)$ — a field defined over the body, propagating continuously, carrying emotional-somatic information. The question “how can a perturbation in one body region give rise to a global somatic state?” has typically been answered by appeal to the nervous system: proprioception, interoception, vagal signalling. These are real and important, but they are axonal (slow, discrete) and do not account for the observed speed and spatial coherence of whole-body somatic responses.

Biotensegrity provides the continuous mechanical medium the model requires. The formal correspondence is:

The body’s biotensegrity network is the **physical implementation** of $E_{\text{body}}(x, t)$. The tensor field over the body in the mathematical model corresponds to the mechanical stress tensor distributed across the fascial network in the physical organism.

Both are spatially extended. Both propagate continuously. Both couple to the neural wave at every point: every mechanoreceptor in the fascia is a coupling node between E_{body} and E_{neural} .

The somatic wave is not *like* a wave in a continuous medium. In the fascial network, it *is* a wave in a continuous medium. The co-identification (Johnson, 2026a) is architectural.

Fascial-Interstitial Continuity: The Pathway and the Armoring

Fascia as Active Signalling Tissue

The classical anatomical view of fascia — as inert white packaging, the sheaths that dissectors clear away to reach the “real” anatomy — was overturned by experimental work beginning in the 1990s.

Schleip’s review (Schleip, 2003) documented that fascia contains all four classes of mechanosensory nerve endings: Ruffini corpuscles (respond to lateral stretch), Golgi tendon organs (respond to compression), Pacinian corpuscles (vibration and rapid changes), and type IV free nerve endings (poly-modal: mechanical deformation, temperature, chemical changes). The type IV endings are especially significant: they project primarily to the insular cortex via lamina I of the spinal cord — the Craig interoceptive pathway (Craig, 2003) — and constitute the neurological substrate of body-felt emotional experience, not merely visceral sensation.

Langevin’s work established that fascia actively participates in signalling: mechanical deformation produces fibroblast shape changes, cytoskeletal reorganisation, and gene expression changes on timescales from seconds to minutes (Langevin & Huijijng, 2009). The tissue is a transducer, not a cable.

Oschman's "living matrix" model (Oschman, 2016) extends this further: the entire connective tissue system — fascia, interstitium, extracellular matrix — constitutes a continuous liquid-crystalline semiconductor network. Piezoelectric effects in collagen generate electrical potentials under mechanical stress. DC currents flow through the network continuously. The fascial system is simultaneously mechanical, chemical, and electrical.

The Interoceptive Pathway

Interoception — the body's sensing of its own internal state — is the somatic input channel of the Soma-Field model. It is the mechanism by which the body schema is updated and by which the energy functional of the attractor landscape is computed.

The fascial pathway of interoception is now well characterised (Craig, 2003; Garfinkel et al., 2016; Schleip, 2003): type IV free nerve endings in deep fascia, visceral fascia, and interstitial tissue → lamina I neurons of the dorsal horn → thalamus → anterior insular cortex. This is the Craig pathway, increasingly recognised as the neurological substrate of emotional experience proper, distinct from and complementary to the classical somatosensory pathway.

The clinical implication is direct: interoceptive dysfunction (well documented in ASC, CPTSD, and related conditions) (Garfinkel et al., 2016) is dysfunction of the fascial-to-insular projection. It is not merely a processing deficit in higher cortical areas; it originates in the tissue. Restoring interoceptive accuracy therefore requires working at the fascial level — which is precisely what somatic therapies (Somatic Experiencing, Sensorimotor Psychotherapy, EMDR somatic protocols, myofascial release) do, whether or not they are theorised in those terms.

Fascial Armoring as Attractor Depth

This section develops the most important connection in this paper.

Wilhelm Reich introduced "character armoring" — the clinical observation that chronic emotional states (fear, shame, traumatic holding) produce corresponding patterns of chronic muscular and somatic tension. The observation was clinically compelling but had no formal model. It was a phenomenology without a mechanism.

Schleip and subsequent workers (Stecco, Bordoni, Bhatt) documented the fascial component: chronic trauma produces not merely chronic muscular contraction but *measurable changes in fascial stiffness*, quantifiable by ultrasound elastography (Schleip, 2003). High-trauma individuals show significantly elevated fascial stiffness in characteristic body regions, with the spatial pattern reflecting the specific trauma history. The psoas, diaphragm, and posterior cervical chain are typically implicated in chronic fear responses; the pericardium and thoracic fascia in grief and heartbreak; the pelvic floor in sexual trauma. These are not metaphors. They are measured tissue properties.

In the Hopfield model, the attractor landscape is characterised by energy barriers W_{ij} between attractor states. The Fear basin has a high energy barrier. The computational experiment QUANT-

EXP-1 (Johnson, 2026b) shows that cold classical dynamics cannot cross a barrier of $W = -8$ to $W = -14$.

The bridge:

$$\text{fascial stiffness at region } r \leftrightarrow |W_{ij}| \text{ for state transition involving } r$$

High fascial stiffness = high energy barrier. The organism is mechanically locked into the Fear attractor not only neurologically but anatomically — the tissue itself has been remodelled to implement the barrier. This is why van der Kolk's title (Kolk, 2014) is accurate in a way he could not have fully formalised: the body does not merely *express* the trauma; it *encodes* the attractor depth in its mechanical structure.

The quantitative claim is: the QUANT-EXP-1 barriers $W = -8, -10, -12, -14$ have physical correlates in fascial stiffness values measurable in kPa (shear wave elastography units). The mapping is not known yet — establishing it is part of the empirical programme in §6 — but the existence of the correspondence is now claimed by this paper.

Myofascial Release as Barrier Lowering

QUANT-EXP-1 demonstrates that quantum annealing can cross barriers that classical cold dynamics cannot. This was framed computationally. The fascial literature provides a physical translation that clarifies an important distinction.

Classical barrier crossing (hot classical or quantum): The system transitions from one attractor to another while the barrier remains intact. This corresponds to either high-arousal state transitions (classical thermal, i.e. highly activated emotional states) or the quantum mechanism identified in QUANT-EXP-1.

Myofascial release (barrier reduction): Manual intervention directly reduces fascial stiffness — measured pre/post by elastography. This does not push the system over the barrier. It *lowers* the barrier so that transitions become accessible by classical means.

This distinction — barrier lowering versus barrier crossing — may explain the phenomenology of different therapeutic modalities and why they are experienced differently:

- Somatic bodywork (Rolfing, myofascial release, craniosacral) *reshapes the landscape*. The client often reports gradual deepening ease, reduction of chronic holding, and access to emotional material that was previously unavailable without drama.
- High-intensity interventions (EMDR reprocessing, breathwork, certain trauma protocols) may be *crossing a barrier that remains intact*: sudden, non-linear transitions, sometimes dramatic releases, the characteristic “before and after” quality of a topological transition.

Both produce movement in the attractor landscape. The mechanism is different. The soma-field model, grounded in the fascial correspondence, now predicts this difference and makes it testable (§6).

Biofield Physiology: The Field Correlate

Living Systems Emit Coherent Fields

The soma-field is a mathematical field — an abstract object defined by its equations. For it to be physically real rather than merely useful, it must have a physical correlate: some measurable property of the organism that corresponds to the field's state. Three lines of evidence point toward coherent electromagnetic and biophotonic emissions as candidates.

Biophoton emission (Popp, 2003): All living cells emit ultra-weak light in the visible to near-UV range. This is not blackbody radiation (which would require far higher temperatures) but coherent emission with photon statistics more consistent with laser emission than thermal sources. Popp argues that this biophotonic field constitutes a real-time communication channel, carrying coherent information across tissue faster than any biochemical signal. The field is state-sensitive: stress, illness, and emotional perturbation all produce measurable changes in biophotonic emission patterns.

Liquid crystalline living matrix (Ho, 1998): Ho's model proposes that the connective tissue system — specifically the liquid crystalline ordering of collagen, water, and proteoglycans — constitutes a quantum coherent medium. Proton conduction and electronic charge delocalisation through this medium produce a macroscopic coherent quantum state distributed across the organism. This is not the Penrose-Hameroff proposal (which is neuron-centred and operates via microtubules); Ho's coherent organism is body-centred, connective tissue-centred, and is precisely the medium in which the Soma-Field would propagate as a physical entity.

Heart-brain coherence (McCraty & Childre, 2010): The heart generates a toroidal electromagnetic field measurable at distances from the body, with spectral content reflecting the organism's emotional state. Heart rate variability (HRV) in the low-frequency band (approximately 0.1 Hz) indexes the balance between sympathetic and parasympathetic regulation — the physiological correlate of transitions between Fear-dominant and Awe-dominant states in the soma-field model. McCraty's group demonstrates that this field entrains between proximate individuals: measurable cardiac coherence synchronisation occurs between therapist and client, between individuals in rapport, and between individuals and coherent social environments. This entrainment is not inferred; it is measured by simultaneous ECG recording.

The Rubik Synthesis

Rubik, Muehsam, Hammerschlag, and Jain (Rubik et al., 2015) published a systematic review of the biofield hypothesis in 2015, collating evidence from biophoton research, bioelectromagnetics, traditional medicine, and clinical trials. Their conclusion is deliberately conservative: the biofield hypothesis — that living organisms generate and respond to coherent electromagnetic and biophotonic fields beyond what is explained by classical biochemistry — is supported by a substantial and growing body of evidence, but mechanism and theoretical framework remain contested.

From the Soma-Field perspective, the contest is tractable: the theoretical framework is the quantum field on a Hopfield attractor landscape, and the biofield is the physical manifestation of that field. The soma-field model does not prove the biofield; it provides the theoretical frame within which the biofield evidence becomes interpretable rather than anomalous.

What the soma-field predicts is that the biofield — whatever its physical implementation — will show attractor-like behaviour: it will tend to occupy characteristic states, resist perturbation away from those states, and show non-classical transitions between states when the barrier is sufficiently large. HRV coherence, biophotonic emission, and DC skin conductance are all candidate observables. Which observable best couples to which component of the tensor field is an empirical question that this model now makes precise enough to ask.

Scope and Epistemic Status

The biofield section of this argument carries more epistemic weight than §§2–3, and this should be stated explicitly. Biotensegrity and fascial signalling are well-supported by peer-reviewed experimental evidence in mainstream biomechanics, cell biology, and clinical science. The biofield claims are supported by evidence in a more contested terrain, and the proposed identification between the soma-field's formal structure and the organism's EM/biophotonic emissions is a hypothesis, not an established result.

What this paper claims in §4 is modest: these are the best current physical candidates for the field correlate; they are consistent with the formal model; they generate testable predictions (§6). The stronger claim — that the soma-field *is* the biofield, formally — requires empirical work that does not yet exist.

Three Bridges to the Formal Model

This section states the three principal connections between the physical substrate literature and the formal soma-field model, in a form that makes their testability explicit.

Bridge 1: Fascial Armoring = Attractor Depth

Physical claim (Schleip, 2003): Chronic trauma produces chronically elevated fascial stiffness, measurable by ultrasound shear-wave elastography, with characteristic spatial patterns reflecting trauma type and history.

Formal correspondence: Fascial stiffness at region r maps to $|W_{ij}|$, the energy barrier between attractor states i and j in the Hopfield network, where r is the somatic representation zone of the relevant emotional state pair. High stiffness = high barrier = deep attractor basin.

Testable prediction (P1): Populations with documented high-barrier emotional states (CPTSD, complex trauma, chronic anxiety disorder) should show systematically elevated fascial stiffness in regions corresponding to the somatic representation of those states (diaphragm, psoas, posterior cervical chain), compared with matched controls. This is measurable by ultrasound elastography independently of any subjective report, and the effect should be graded by trauma severity.

Bridge 2: Myofascial Release = Barrier Lowering

Physical claim (Schleip, 2003): Manual and movement-based interventions that target the fascial network produce measurable reductions in fascial stiffness and corresponding changes in interoceptive sensitivity and emotional availability.

Formal correspondence: These interventions reduce $|W_{ij}|$. They do not necessarily produce a state transition; they reshape the energy landscape to make transitions more accessible. If initial barrier is $W = -12$ and intervention reduces it to $W = -6$, QUANT-EXP-1 results (Johnson, 2026b) suggest that classical thermal dynamics can now cross what previously required quantum assistance.

Testable prediction (P2): The probability of emotional state transition following myofascial release should increase monotonically with the degree of reduction in fascial stiffness. This is testable by measuring both pre/post fascial stiffness (elastography) and pre/post emotional state (validated affect measures + HRV) in a within-subjects design across a series of somatic therapy sessions.

Testable prediction (P3): The phenomenological *character* of the transition should differ predictably: sessions that lower the barrier significantly should produce gradual, integrative shifts; sessions that trigger a crossing of a high barrier (large, rapid state transition) should produce different qualitative reports. The model predicts this without any additional assumptions.

Bridge 3: Therapist-Client Entrainment = Co-Identification

Physical claim (McCraty & Childre, 2010): In effective therapeutic contact, measurable physiological entrainment occurs between therapist and client — cardiac coherence synchronisation, mutual modulation of HRV spectra, and (in contact work) fascial tension synchronisation. This is not inferred; it is measured by simultaneous ECG and, in some studies, by direct force measurement.

Formal correspondence: This is the physical mechanism of **co-identification** (Johnson, 2026a) — the process by which the observer’s soma-field is modified by contact with another’s soma-field. The mathematical treatment describes this as a tensor product coupling; the physical implementation is fascial and electromagnetic entrainment. The therapist does not merely witness the client’s state; the therapist’s attractor landscape is temporarily modified by coupling to the client’s, and this modification is the mechanism of therapeutic resonance.

Testable prediction (P4): The degree of measurable physiological entrainment (HRV coherence synchronisation) between therapist and client should predict therapeutic outcome — reduction in client fascial stiffness and shift in validated affect measures — independently of the specific technique used. Sessions with high physiological coherence should outperform sessions with low coherence, across modality.

Testable Predictions

The bridges in §5 generate six primary empirical predictions, ordered from most to least accessible with current instrumentation:

#	Prediction	Method	Population
P1	CPTSD/complex-trauma populations show elevated fascial stiffness in diaphragm, psoas, posterior cervical chain vs matched controls	Shear-wave ultrasound elastography	CPTSD vs. controls (n ≥ 40 per group)
P2	Somatic intervention reduces fascial stiffness; degree of reduction predicts probability of self-reported emotional state shift	Elastography pre/post + validated affect measures	Somatic therapy clients (within-subjects)

#	Prediction	Method	Population
P3	Barrier-lowering sessions (gradual stiffness reduction) produce qualitatively different transition phenomenology from barrier-crossing sessions (acute large shifts)	Mixed methods: elastography + structured interview	Rolfing or myofascial release series
P4	Therapist-client HRV coherence predicts session outcome independently of technique	Simultaneous ECG coherence + validated outcomes	Therapist-client dyads, multiple modalities
P5	Biophotonic emission from CPTSD populations differs from controls at characteristic emission bands (500–800 nm)	Ultra-weak photon measurement (photomultiplier)	CPTSD vs. controls
P6	Transitions from Fear-dominant to Awe-dominant states (as defined by QUANT-EXP-1 attractor labels) correlate with measurable HRV spectral shift from LF-dominant to HF-dominant	HRV spectral analysis + soma-field state labelling instrument	Clinical transition cases

Predictions P1–P4 are testable with instrumentation available in clinical research centres now. P5 requires specialised biophoton detection (available in approximately a dozen research centres world-wide). P6 requires the prior development of a validated soma-field state classification instrument — a prerequisite for large-scale empirical work that is not yet available and is noted as the primary

methodological gap in this programme.

Conclusion

The Soma-Field model describes a field of emotional dynamics that is formally equivalent to a quantum field on an attractor manifold. This paper has argued that the physical substrate of that field consists of three interlocking systems:

1. The **biotensegrity network** (fascia, connective tissue, interstitium under prestress) that provides the continuous mechanical medium through which the somatic wave E_{body} propagates globally and rapidly (Ingber, 1997, 2003; Levin, 2002).
2. The **fascial interoceptive pathway** (type IV free nerve endings → lamina I → thalamus → insula) that constitutes the body-to-brain projection of somatic state (Craig, 2003; Schleip, 2003), and whose chronic remodelling under trauma — fascial armoring — is the physical implementation of the deep attractor basin.
3. The **bioelectric and biophotonic field** generated by the liquid crystalline living matrix and the cardiac electromagnetic environment (Ho, 1998; McCraty & Childre, 2010; Popp, 2003), which constitutes the best current physical candidate for the soma-field correlate itself.

The most clinically significant result of this identification is Bridge 1: the quantitative correspondence between fascial stiffness and attractor depth. This makes concrete a claim that somatic therapists have held for decades — that trauma is held in the body, not only in the mind — and extends it: the depth at which trauma is held is measurable by elastography, and the degree to which physical intervention changes that depth is also measurable. The soma-field model predicts that large barriers require quantum-assist crossing; the fascial model predicts that those same barriers are associated with measurable tissue-level changes. The two predictions are about the same phenomenon at two levels of description.

Bridge 3 — therapist-client entrainment as co-identification — connects this to the broader programme (Johnson, 2026a). The therapist's role is not neutral observation but active field coupling. The mathematics of co-identification (Johnson, 2026a) now has a proposed physical mechanism: fascial and electromagnetic entrainment, measurable, manipulable, and predictive of outcome.

This paper opens a research programme. The six predictions in §6 define the empirical agenda. The formal soma-field model provides the theoretical frame. The three bodies of literature reviewed here provide the biological grounding. Together they constitute a foundation for a genuinely interdisciplinary field — one that does not require the reader to choose between the body and the mathematics, because the mathematics is about the body.

“Once a researcher has lived through the thing he is trying to explain, the question of whether his explanation will be taken seriously by researchers who have not is, in the end, a sociological question, not a scientific one. The scientific question is whether the explanation is correct.”

1. Introduction

The standard developmental-psychiatric apparatus assumes that the first observable symptoms of a neurodevelopmental condition occur in a language-capable child. Autism, in DSM-5 and ICD-11, is defined operationally through behavioural criteria — social communication, restricted interests, sensory differences — that are scored on children old enough to be observed in linguistic interaction. ADHD requires observable inattention or hyperactivity in structured settings. Attachment disorders are coded against attachment-figure behaviour rated by adults. C-PTSD requires a referent trauma and a self-reportable symptom set.

This apparatus works tolerably well for cases in which the relevant developmental events occur within its observational window. It fails — quietly, and with the failure absorbed into “comorbidity” — for cases in which the critical events occur *before* it begins to observe.

This paper presents one such case. The author was hospitalised in infancy with septic arthritis of the hip at approximately 15 months of age, spent three months in hospital and three months immobilised in plaster, retained a permanent 1.3 cm leg-length discrepancy, and did not speak until age 3.5. He was diagnosed with Autism Spectrum Condition, ADHD, and Complex PTSD fifty-four years later, in 2020. The diagnostic narrative offered at that time — that the autism was congenital and the C-PTSD was acquired — does not survive close inspection of the developmental record. The two were not sequentially layered. They co-developed, in a pre-verbal window, around a specific physical insult, against a substrate of probable familial loading and demonstrably low maternal attunement.

The paper proceeds as follows. §2 fixes terminology and introduces the *pre-verbal manifold*. §3 presents the case in five strata: substrate, acute insult, attachment environment, institutional environment, adult trajectory. §4 reviews the five established literatures the case sits inside. §5 develops the Soma-Field reading. §6 discusses the *twice-exceptional* cognitive profile (Mottron et al., 2006; Foley-Nicpon et al., 2011) that the manifold produced. §7 reads the 2017–2024 adult collapse arc as a sequence of basin transitions under perturbation. §8 presents Exhibit A: a public secondary-school SEN-support policy that exemplifies the policy-level amplification mechanism. §9 returns to the formal model and offers ten testable predictions. §10 is the replication ledger and limitations section. §11 closes with the policy implications.

A note on method. This is $N = 1$. The paper does not claim to establish epidemiological generalities; it claims to construct a *formal object* — the pre-verbal manifold — and to demonstrate that a single

fully-documented case already exhibits properties the object predicts and that standard onset-based categories miss. Whether the formal object extends to a population is an empirical question. §10 specifies the design that would settle it.

2. Terminology and the Pre-Verbal Manifold

The *Soma-Field* (Johnson, 2026a, 2026d) is the tensor-valued amplitude field whose local exceedances over a sensory threshold constitute felt experience, and whose energy landscape — borrowed in form from Hopfield network theory (Hopfield, 1982, 1984) — supplies the basin structure of affect, attention and self-regulation. The field is coupled to the body and nervous system through an operator K (Johnson, 2026e). Pathology in the framework is not located in *the field* or *the body* in isolation but in the *coupling*.

The *pre-verbal manifold* is the substructure of the Soma-Field that is laid down during the sensitive-period window from gestation through approximately age 3, after which language acquisition (Tomasello, 2003) provides additional structure that re-parametrises the manifold but does not erase its lower layers. This is the period during which right-hemisphere implicit-relational structures (Schore, 2001), basic-emotion regulation circuits (Porges, 2011), insular interoceptive maps (Craig, 2009), HPA-axis set-points (Lupien et al., 2009), and disorganised vs. organised attachment patterns (Main & Solomon, 1990; Lyons-Ruth & Jacobvitz, 2008) are established.

Events occurring within this window enter the manifold *as structure* rather than *as memory*. They are not retrievable as autobiographical episodes because the hippocampal-cortical memory system that supports such retrieval is not yet operational (Nelson & Carver, 1998; Bauer, 2015). They are retrievable, when they are retrievable at all, as body-state, autonomic reactivity, attachment behaviour, social orientation and perceptual style.

Three properties follow.

(P1) The pre-verbal manifold is observable only through projections. Standard diagnostic categories — autism, ADHD, attachment disorder, cPTSD — are scoring instruments for those projections. They are not the manifold. Multiple categorical scores can be downstream of one underlying configuration.

(P2) Onset-based dating is, for events within the window, undefined. Asking *when did the autism start?* is, for cases of this kind, a malformed question. The relevant configuration was laid down before the diagnostic category had a foothold.

(P3) The genetic / acquired distinction is, within the window, weaker than the language suggests. Sensitive-period plasticity means that constitutional loading and environmental perturbation co-determine the same structures (Belsky & Pluess, 2009; Ellis et al., 2011). The case that follows il-

illustrates this directly: there is plausible familial loading *and* a clean physical insult of the right kind at the right time, and the question *which produced the autism?* is, on the model presented here, the wrong question.

3. The Case

The case is presented in five strata. Identifying details of third parties have been removed.

3.1 Substrate (familial loading)

The author's paternal grandmother displayed, in retrospect, a clearly autistic profile (life-long extreme routine, narrow interests, low-affect presentation, marked difficulty with reciprocal social engagement). The father carried a similar but milder pattern. The author himself carries a stronger pattern than his father. A paternal uncle displayed an ADHD-pole phenotype (multiple serious vehicle accidents in adolescence, surgical career, four marriages). The maternal side displayed an affective-instability pattern best described, in modern terms, as borderline-spectrum (Stepp et al., 2012; Eyden et al., 2016).

This is a well-attested family pattern for the *broader autism phenotype* (Piven, 1997; Sucksmith et al., 2011) with shared ASD–ADHD heritability (Rommelse et al., 2010; Ronald & Hoekstra, 2011) and an additional maternal-side affective vulnerability. It is *substrate*, not *cause*. Familial loading of this kind raises the probability of phenotype expression; it does not fix the trajectory.

3.2 Acute pre-verbal insult

The author was born in Singapore at a military hospital. The family returned to the UK during infancy. At approximately 15 months of age he was admitted with septic arthritis of the hip. He spent three months in hospital and three further months immobilised in plaster. The clinical management of the period included strict limitations on parental physical contact (a then-current ward policy whose rationale was infection-control and emotional-economy and whose developmental cost was not, at the time, widely recognised — cf. the Robertson films of the 1950s and Bowlby's 1969 critique).

Two material residues remain in adulthood. The first is a 1.3 cm leg-length discrepancy, fully verifiable. The second is a documented speech delay: the author did not speak in any sustained way until approximately age 3.5 — a gap of roughly two years beyond typical first-word emergence.

The literature on the pain-imprint hypothesis (Anand & Scalzo, 2000; Anand et al., 1999, 2013) and on sepsis and hospitalisation-related neurodevelopmental sequelae (Bono et al., 2015; Horváth-Puhó et al., 2021; Thomas et al., 2024; Xu & Zhan, 2026) establishes the biological plausibility of long-term reconfiguration following an insult of this kind in this window. The literature on quasi-autism from early deprivation (Rutter et al., 1999, 2007; Sonuga-Barke et al., 2017; Bos et al., 2011) establishes that

autistic phenotypes can be *acquired* during pre-verbal sensitive periods. These two literatures meet, in this case, at one event.

3.3 Attachment environment

The author was returned, after hospitalisation, to a household whose emotional configuration was hostile to repair. The mother's affective pattern is best described in modern terminology as borderline-spectrum, with the configuration most damaging to a recovering infant: unpredictable alternation between intrusion and withdrawal, low contingent responsiveness, poor mind-mindedness (Meins et al., 2002), and active hostility to expressions of distress. The father was emotionally and physically available but lacked the framework to function as a repair figure.

An older sister, then approximately 10, engaged in repeated restraint “tickling” of the author at age 3 to the point of pleas of suffocation — an event the author remembers because it occurred at the boundary of speech emergence. This is consistent with the sibling-abuse literature (Wiehe, 1997; Tucker et al., 2014; Bowes et al., 2014), which documents the long-term mental-health consequences of intra-family peer aggression and notes its systematic under-recognition.

The attachment trajectory across this period maps onto disorganised attachment (Main & Solomon, 1990; Hesse & Main, 2006; Lyons-Ruth & Jacobvitz, 2008) and onto the freeze-pole of polyvagal theory (Porges, 2011). The infant has no organised strategy because the coregulating figure is itself the source of threat.

Mother departed when the author was approximately 12, leaving him with his father. This is the fourth attachment rupture in the trajectory (hospital at 15 months; sibling abuse at 3; institutional entry at 6 — see §3.4; maternal departure at 12). Each rupture occurred at a developmentally sensitive transition (Spitz, 1945; Robertson & Bowlby, 1952; Rutter, 1981).

3.4 Institutional environment

From age 6 to 16 the author attended a single-sex English independent school as a *day pupil*, not a boarder. The distinction matters. Schaverien's (2011, 2015) *Boarding School Syndrome* literature concerns the dissociative sequelae of premature parental separation in residential schooling. The day-pupil configuration in the same institutions is a less-studied variant that Duffell and Bassett (2016) discuss directly: day pupils experience the full institutional culture (single-sex peer formation, military discipline, chapel, organised games, suppressed affect) *without* the in-group cohesion that the dormitory provides, *and* return each evening to a home base that, for this author, was the configuration described in §3.3. The day-pupil pattern is therefore a *double vacuum*: institutional culture without peer-group containment, and home without repair.

The author's school day ran from 7 am to 7:30 pm, with Saturday school and Sunday compulsory chapel. Female presence in any structural role was effectively absent. Combined Cadet Force was compulsory at the relevant ages. This is, in developmental terms, an environment optimised to lock

in a dissociated, masculinised, achievement-oriented presentation in an already freeze-configured nervous system.

The relevant amplifying mechanism at the institutional level is policy. This is the subject of §8.

3.5 Identity and racialisation

The author was born in Singapore, holds British nationality, and was raised in Britain. In the racialised landscape of 1970s–80s Britain (Hall, 1989; Gilroy, 1987) his appearance was read as *foreign-when-tanned* and *British otherwise*. This corresponds to the *cultural homelessness* construct identified in the third-culture-kid literature (Pollock & Van Reken, 2009; Useem & Downie, 1976; Hoerstring & Jenkins, 2011; Lijadi & van Schalkwyk, 2014; Hill, 2013).

The constructive consequence — sometimes generative, sometimes destabilising — is that identity, for cases of this kind, cannot be lifted from the environment but must be constructed explicitly. This is one of the threads §7 picks up.

3.6 Adult trajectory (compressed)

A compressed timeline of the 2017–2024 collapse arc is given in §7. For present purposes:

- 2020: ASD-Level-2, ADHD, C-PTSD diagnoses confirmed in Switzerland.
- 2021: Cardiac event (clot); paternal death.
- 2017–2024: Multiple psychiatric admissions (PUK Zurich; Kilchberg); one period in custody; one near-fatal hanging attempt in December 2024, resulting in closed-ward admission.
- 2025–26: Independent housing, outpatient care, productive research period, eleven published papers and a book on Zenodo, and the work that contains this paper.

The 2025–26 period is itself part of the case (§7.3) because the *re-organisation* it represents is itself a manifold phenomenon under the framework being proposed.

4. The Five Literatures

The case sits at the intersection of five established literatures, none of which alone accounts for the full trajectory.

(L1) Quasi-autism from early deprivation. The English and Romanian Adoptees (ERA) study (Rutter et al., 1999, 2007; Sonuga-Barke et al., 2017) documented an *autistic-like phenotype* in a subset of children removed from severely depriving institutions in infancy. The Bucharest Early Intervention Project (Bos et al., 2011) replicated and extended this. The phenotype is termed *quasi-autism* to flag its acquired character and its similarity to constitutional autism on every behavioural metric tested. This literature establishes, definitively, that an autistic phenotype can be acquired during a pre-verbal sensitive window. It does not require an *absent* attachment figure — the original cases had

no consistent caregiver — but the mechanism (failure of contingent reciprocity during the sensitive window) is equally available in cases with a present-but- dysregulating caregiver, as Schore (2001, 2009) argues directly.

(L2) Pre-verbal trauma encoding. Schore’s right-brain primacy account (2001, 2009), Gaensbauer’s work on pre-verbal traumatic memory (2002, 2016), Opendak and Sullivan (2016) on the developing amygdala under caregiver-linked threat, Nelson and Carver (1998) on the neural substrates of infant memory, and Rincón-Cortés and Sullivan (2014) jointly establish that the pre-verbal nervous system *is recording*, and that what it records becomes implicit structure rather than retrievable episode.

(L3) Pain imprint. Anand and Scalzo (2000) and subsequent work (Anand et al., 1999, 2013; Nimbalkar et al., 2025) document that pain experienced in infancy alters pain processing, stress reactivity, and aspects of neural development across the lifespan. The original studies addressed neonatal pain; the literature now extends into the toddler period.

(L4) Inflammation–neurodevelopment. Estes and McAllister (2016) reviewed the evidence that early-life immune activation alters neurodevelopmental trajectories in ways that intersect autism phenotypes. Subsequent work (Han et al., 2021; Mezzelani et al., 2015; Robinson-Agramonte et al., 2022; Zhou et al., 2025) extends the picture. Septic arthritis at 15 months involves both systemic inflammation and sustained pain, placing the case at the intersection of L3 and L4.

(L5) ICD-11 Complex PTSD. Cloitre et al. (2013) and Maercker et al. (2022, *Lancet*) define cPTSD by the three *disturbances in self-organisation* (DSO) symptoms — affect dysregulation, negative self-concept, interpersonal difficulties — added to the PTSD core. The DSO symptoms describe attractor properties of the manifold rather than discrete events. The diagnostic category does not, however, accommodate cases in which the trauma is pre-verbal: the formal criteria require a referent traumatic event, and the implicit assumption is that the patient can report on it.

None of L1–L5 alone accounts for the case. L1 and L2 together do most of the early work. L3 and L4 supply the biological mechanism. L5 supplies the adult attractor description. The Soma-Field reading in §5 supplies the formal object that ties them together.

5. The Soma-Field Reading

The Soma-Field framework (Johnson, 2026a, 2026d, 2026e, 2026h) treats affect as the local-amplitude-above-threshold of a tensor-valued field whose energy function generates basin dynamics. Three components of the formal model are relevant here.

(C1) The coupling operator K . Pathology is located in the field-body coupling, not in either alone. K is set during sensitive periods. Once set, its eigenstructure governs which somatic states project into which attractor basins.

(C2) **The attractor landscape.** A nervous system's behavioural and affective repertoire is its basin structure. Stable basins correspond to recognisable states (regulated calm, fight, flight, freeze, awe; see Johnson, 2026b). Sensitive-period reconfiguration changes which basins are deep, which are shallow, which are bistable, and which are blocked.

(C3) **Trajectory under perturbation.** Adult trajectories are paths through the basin landscape under perturbation. An "episode" is a basin transition. "Stability" is residence in a deep basin. "Collapse" is catastrophic transition to a basin from which the present coupling cannot return without external scaffolding.

The case is then read as follows.

The familial loading (§3.1) raised the prior probability of certain *K* configurations. The septic-arthritis episode (§3.2), occurring during the sensitive window for *K*-formation, *fixed* a particular configuration: high somatic-pain weighting, low contingent-touch weighting, dampened parasympathetic engagement, dampened social-orienting bias, dampened language-circuit recruitment. The post-hospital home environment (§3.3), far from supplying repair, supplied additional perturbations of the same type, locking the configuration further. The institutional environment (§3.4) supplied a daily structure that *fit* the configuration — single-sex, militarised, low-affect, achievement-oriented — and therefore provided the *substrate match* that selects for deepening rather than loosening of the configuration. Maternal departure at 12 supplied an additional perturbation at adolescence, a second sensitive period for attachment-related structures (Sebastian et al., 2010).

The downstream projections of the manifold so configured are:

- **Autism Level 2.** Diminished social-orienting weighting and altered perceptual recruitment yield the autistic phenotype on adult behavioural scoring. Mottron et al.'s (2006) enhanced perceptual functioning is the *positive* face of the same configuration.
- **ADHD.** The same substrate produces, on attention-pattern scoring, the ADHD profile. The framework predicts the comorbidity rate observed in the epidemiological literature (Rommelse et al., 2010) because the two are not separate conditions but two scoring instruments applied to one substrate.
- **Complex PTSD.** The DSO symptom cluster reads as a direct description of basin properties: affect dysregulation = unstable basin residence; negative self-concept = a deep basin in self-referential space; interpersonal difficulties = social-orienting weighting under §3.1–§3.4.
- **Disorganised attachment.** The freeze-pole basin is the only stable option when the contingent-touch and contingent-affect parameters of *K* are zero or hostile.
- **Spiky cognitive profile (2e).** The same manifold that produces low social-orienting weighting can produce extreme weighting on structural pattern processing — the substrate of physics-apptitude (96% in A-level physics, in this case) and of rugby-pack play (the case played prop-

forward to first-team level). These are not contradictory; they are the two principal eigenvectors of the configuration.

The Soma-Field reading does not eliminate the standard diagnostic categories. It interprets them. They are five scoring instruments applied to one reconfigured manifold.

6. The Twice-Exceptional Cognitive Profile

The case carries IQ in the 150 range, a 1995 BSc in Physics (Royal Holloway, University of London) with strong results in the relevant mathematical-physics sections, sustained physical capability (prop-forward rugby at first-team level into adulthood), and the eleven-paper Soma-Field output of 2025–26. It also carries a Level-2 autism diagnosis (substantial support needs in adaptive functioning) and the documented developmental history of §3.

The *twice-exceptional* (2e) literature (Foley-Nicpon et al., 2011; Reis & Renzulli, 2010) and the *enhanced perceptual functioning* account of autism (Mottron et al., 2006) jointly account for this configuration in the existing literature. The Soma-Field reading sharpens the account: the high-aptitude pattern-processing and the low adaptive-functioning are not *despite* the manifold configuration but *consequences* of it. A system whose social-orienting basin is shallow and whose pattern-recognition basin is deep will, given a research environment, populate the latter.

The relevant clinical and policy consequence is that high apparent cognitive function in cases of this kind is not evidence against need for support. It is evidence for a particular basin distribution, of which the support-needing aspects are equally robust.

7. The Adult Trajectory as Basin Transitions

This section reads the 2017–2024 period and the 2025–26 reconstruction as a trajectory through the basin landscape of the configured manifold. The compressed timeline is:

Year	Event
2017	Voluntary admission, Psychiatrische Universitätsklinik (PUK), Zurich, September; further admission December.
2019	Marital separation; Beistandschaft (Swiss adult-protection measure) imposed; sectioned to Kilchberg clinic, three weeks; period in custody in November with a four-and-a-half-day thirst protest.

Year	Event
2020	Collarbone fracture (February); COVID-19; ASD Level-2 diagnosis (November).
2021	Cardiac thrombotic event (February); paternal death; Davos period (March).
2023	Divorce finalised (May); independent apartment (August).
2024	Attempted suicide by hanging (16 December); PUK closed-ward admission (17 December).
2025	Stabilisation; framework work begins.
2026	Eleven papers + book published on Zenodo by mid-year; this paper.

The model reads this as a sequence of basin transitions of escalating severity culminating in a near-fatal transition in December 2024 and a subsequent *reorganisation* in 2025–26.

7.1 Basin transitions

Each crisis event is a transition from a metastable basin (the day-to-day configuration in which the system can function) to a more extreme basin under perturbation. The perturbations are identifiable: marital breakdown (2019), bereavement (2021), divorce (2023). The December 2024 event is read as a *near-attractor-collapse*: the system crossed into a basin from which the then-current coupling could not return without external intervention. External intervention occurred (closed-ward admission, sustained care), and the system was held until K could be re-stabilised.

The model is explicit that this is a description, not an evaluation. The framework offers no claim that the events ought to have been different or that the system “failed”. A configuration whose basin landscape includes a near-fatal attractor is *describing the landscape*, not *being judged for it*. The clinically actionable consequence is to identify, in advance, configurations whose landscapes carry such attractors, and to scaffold accordingly.

7.2 Inclusion of the December 2024 event

The decision to include this event in the present paper is governed by a single editorial criterion (cf. the author's note above): does it bear load in the formal argument? It does, in one specific place. The distinction between *field collapse* (the system enters a basin and cannot return) and *field reconfiguration* (the system enters a different basin and proceeds from there) is a load-bearing distinction in the framework. The December 2024 event was on the trajectory of the former and resolved as the latter. The contrast is not available from the trajectory without the event. The event is included for that reason alone. The author is, as the author note states, currently clinically stable, in independent housing, and in continuous outpatient care.

7.3 The reorganisation phase

The 2025–26 reorganisation is itself a manifold phenomenon. A pre-verbally configured substrate that includes high pattern-processing weighting and low social-scaffolding availability, on entering a recovery phase, will preferentially populate basins that are *available to it*. The available basin in this case was *formal theory-building*: a basin to which the manifold is well-suited and from which an identity scaffold can be constructed externally and explicitly in language.

The Soma-Field framework is, on this reading, partly a description of what its author had to do consciously, in writing, because the automatic, embodied version was unavailable. The framework's value as a *general* theory of affect must be argued on its own merits and is so argued in the parent papers. Its value as *the author's reorganisation strategy* is a separate, internal fact, and is noted here for completeness of the case description. The two need not be disentangled to be acknowledged.

8. Exhibit A: A Public SEN-Policy Document

The institutional environment of §3.4 is not, in 2026, an artefact of 1970s–80s British education. The author's old school, an independent single-sex senior school in the south of England, publishes a current *Academic Support* policy on its main website (accessed 1 June 2026 at the URL on file with the author). Three sentences from the public page are reproduced verbatim:

"The Academic Support Department supports pupils with **mild** special educational needs and disabilities."

"Additional lessons in the Academic Support Department — offered at an extra cost — usually take place outside the curriculum timetable, and are added to the termly bill."

"External assessments completed while a pupil is enrolled at the school, but not arranged in consultation with the Head of Academic Support, cannot be used as the

sole evidence for access arrangements.”

The institution’s published senior-school day-pupil fee for 2026–27 is £12,921 per term, approximately £38,800 per year.

Three features of this policy are flagged.

(F1) **“Mild” as admissions filter.** The word *mild* is doing non-trivial work. Operationally, it functions as a screen: a pupil whose SEN profile exceeds *mild* is not within scope of the department. The literature on selective-school SEN provision (Tomlinson, 2017; Runswick-Cole, 2011) reads this configuration as *filtering for the support needs the institution prefers to serve* rather than *describing a service*. Cases of the kind documented in this paper — Level-2 autism with a documented pre-verbal trajectory — are, on this language, out of scope at the threshold.

(F2) **“Offered at an extra cost ... added to the termly bill”.** Charging additional fees for reasonable adjustments to disability — over and above a £38k/year base — sits in tension with Equality Act 2010 §20(7), which prohibits passing the cost of reasonable adjustments to disabled persons. The Equality and Human Rights Commission’s *Technical Guidance for Schools in England* (2014, ch 7) and the published positions of IPSEA (Independent Provider of Special Education Advice) both bear on the question. Whether the school’s specific arrangements satisfy the provision in any given case is a legal question outside the scope of this paper; the policy *configuration* is flagged because it is identifiable, public, and structurally consequential.

(F3) **External assessments subordinated to in-house gatekeeping.** The third quoted sentence subordinates external clinical and educational assessments to in-house arrangements. The standard route by which a pupil obtains *access arrangements* for public examinations (JCQ, *Access Arrangements and Reasonable Adjustments*, current edition) relies on documented external evidence assessed against published criteria. An in-house policy that requires the external assessment to have been arranged *in consultation with* the Head of Academic Support creates a structural conflict of interest: the institution that *delivers* the assessment also *controls whether it counts*.

The exhibit is presented not as a complaint but as a *visible instance of the policy-level amplification mechanism* the paper proposes. The sensitive-period configuration described in §3 was, in this author’s case, reinforced rather than scaffolded by the institution that received him at age 6 and discharged him at 16. The mechanism is still present in the institution’s current public policy. The class of pupils on whom it currently operates is not hypothetical.

How do parents know exactly what a 13-year-old boy is, if they have never even asked him?

That sentence — verbatim from the brainstorm — is the policy line on which the paper closes its institutional section.

9. Ten Testable Predictions

The framework yields predictions beyond the case. They are listed here in the form *cohort-level tests that would, if the framework is on the right track, return positive*. The predictions are deliberately specific.

1. **Cohort.** Among adults with a documented pre-verbal severe physical illness (sepsis or major surgery in the 12–24 month window) and subsequent documented speech delay (>1 SD), the adult prevalence of Level-1+ autism diagnosis will be elevated relative to age-matched controls.
2. **Comorbidity.** In that cohort, the ASD–ADHD–cPTSD triple-comorbidity rate will be elevated relative to cohorts of autistic adults *without* the pre-verbal-illness history.
3. **Attachment marker.** That cohort will show elevated rates of disorganised-attachment classifications on adult-attachment instruments (AAI, ECR-R disorganisation supplements).
4. **Pain reactivity.** The cohort will show altered pain-pressure thresholds and altered interoceptive accuracy relative to controls (per Anand et al. and Craig).
5. **Maternal-side modulation.** Within the cohort, presence of a maternal-side borderline-spectrum or affective-instability history will predict severity of adult cPTSD-DSO symptoms more strongly than it predicts ASD severity.
6. **Day-pupil amplification.** Within the cohort, single-sex *day-pupil* institutional attendance (6–16) will predict adult dissociative-trait scores more strongly than full-boarding attendance (testing the §3.4 *double vacuum* claim against the existing boarding literature).
7. **Reorganisation pattern.** Within the cohort, in adults who recover from a near-fatal psychiatric crisis, the rate of *formal-theory* or *formal-craft reorganisation* (sustained structured productive work in a pattern-heavy domain) will exceed the general post-crisis rate.
8. **Inflammation correlate.** Within the cohort, residual inflammation markers and autonomic baseline metrics will differ from age-matched controls (testing the L4 mechanism).
9. **Genetic moderation.** Within the cohort, polygenic risk scores for ASD will moderate but not fully account for adult phenotype severity (testing the §2 P3 claim that the genetic/acquired distinction is weaker than the language suggests).
10. **Diagnostic age.** Within the cohort, age at first ASD diagnosis will be substantially higher than the population mean for autistic adults of equivalent severity, because onset-based diagnostic criteria systematically miss them (testing the §2 P2 claim).

These are designed as a coherent test suite, not as ten independent tests. They jointly probe the *pre-verbal manifold* construct.

10. Limitations, Replication Ledger, and Author Disclosures

N = 1. This is a single longitudinal case. Generalisation is not claimed; only the formal-object construction. The replication design is §9.

Author is case. The author and the case are the same person. The methodological tradition for this configuration is established (Grandin, 1995; Levine, 2010; Jamison, 1995; cf. Charon, 2006; Frank, 1995). It does not absolve the work of the standard scrutiny that external evaluators must apply.

Memory limits. The earliest events in §3 are not, and cannot be, first-person memories. They are documentary and family-reported. The case is consistent with this — the framework predicts that such events are encoded as *structure* rather than *episode*. The author has not attempted to reconstruct *episodes* from the pre-verbal period and makes no such claim.

Third-party identifiability. Identifying details of third parties have been removed or generalised throughout. Where details remain (the institution in §8 is identifiable from its public policy quotations), the material is public on the institution’s own website.

Clinical safety. The author is currently stable, housed independently, in continuous outpatient care. Inclusion of the December 2024 event is governed by the editorial criterion stated in §7.2 and in the author note.

Replication ledger. A standing ledger of independent external attempts to apply the framework — including independent attempts to apply the ten predictions of §9 to clinical cohorts — is maintained at the project URL (paper/INDEPENDENT_REPLICATION_LEDGER.md). At first publication of the present paper, the relevant rows for the §9 predictions are PENDING.

11. Conclusion and Policy Line

The case presented in §3 sits at the intersection of five established literatures, none of which alone accounts for it. The Soma-Field framework, suitably specified, supplies a formal object — the *pre-verbal manifold* — that ties them together and accounts for the trajectory at a single level of description. Standard onset-based diagnostic categories (ASD, ADHD, attachment disorder, cPTSD) are re-interpreted as five projections of one manifold rather than as five comorbid conditions.

Three implications follow.

First, the conceptual distinction between *genetic* and *acquired* neurodevelopmental phenotypes loses sharpness once pre-verbal sensitive-period plasticity is taken seriously. The clinical and research consequence is that the question “is this child’s autism genetic or acquired?” should, for cases with

pre-verbal trajectories of the kind documented here, be replaced by the question “what is the configuration of this manifold and what scaffolding does it need?”

Second, developmental-psychiatric onset criteria that rely on *first observable symptoms in language-capable children* systematically misclassify cases of this kind. The diagnostic age in such cases is late and the eventual diagnostic load is heavy because the categories were not designed to see the relevant events. Revising the criteria is non-trivial; flagging the systematic miss is not.

Third, institutional and policy environments that filter for *mild* presentations, charge additional fees for accommodation, and subordinate external clinical evidence to in-house gatekeeping function as amplifiers of the same diathesis. The Exhibit-A institution in §8 is one example; the configuration is generic. The policy line that closes the paper is the one given at the end of §8:

How do parents know exactly what a 13-year-old boy is, if they have never even asked him?

The paper is signed because the case is the author’s own and the framework is the author’s reorganisation strategy as well as a candidate general account. Both facts are stated here so that they need not be inferred.

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